



Common Communication Pitfalls

Why it Matters

Even supportive managers can say things that shut down honesty. Small phrases can make people feel dismissed or judged. Noticing what *not* to say helps keep trust intact.

Pitfalls

Communication Pitfalls	Why it's a Pitfall	Phrases to Watch For	Try this Instead
 Reassuring Too Quickly	Dismisses or rushes past real emotion.	"You'll be fine" "Don't worry about it" "It'll all work out"	"That sounds tough" "What part feels hardest right now?" "Take your time — I'm listening"
 Minimizing Their Experience	Invalidates or compares their feelings.	"At least it's not as bad as..." "That's not so bad" "Could be worse"	"That sounds frustrating" "I'm glad you told me" "Your experience matters"
 Judging or Adding Guilt	Adds pressure or subtle blame.	"Why didn't you tell me sooner?" "That's not how I'd do it" "You should've said something earlier"	"Thanks for letting me know now" "You don't have to explain everything" "I'm just glad you shared it"
 Fixing Too Fast	Skips over listening and may feel controlling.	"You should talk to HR" "Just try meditating" "Here's what I'd do"	"Do you want to vent or talk through options?" "I'm here to listen first" "We can figure out next steps together"
 Rushing to Problem Solve	Shifts attention away from them.	"I've been through the same thing" "That happened to me once" "I know exactly how you feel"	"Thanks for trusting me with this" "I'm here for you" "Want to share more about what this feels like for you?"

